



The tortoise
Using the tortoise formation to attack the walls or gate of a city required considerable practice to coordinate the movements of all the soldiers involved *(right)*. If they executed the manoeuvre successfully, they were immune to the arrows and other missiles directed against them by the defenders *(far right)*.

> "LEST THE SOLDIERS ... SHOULD BE SEPARATED FROM THEIR COMRADES, EVERY COHORT HAD ITS SHIELDS PAINTED IN A MANNER PECULIAR TO ITSELF. THE NAME OF EACH SOLDIER WAS ALSO WRITTEN ON HIS SHIELD, TOGETHER WITH THE NUMBER OF THE COHORT AND CENTURY TO WHICH HE BELONGED."
>
> **VEGETIUS**, *A MILITARY DIGEST,* 4TH CENTURY CE

In this aptly named formation – *testudo* is Latin for tortoise – a body of soldiers would advance with shields covering them from above as well as from all sides. When they reached the walls, they would either attack them with metal bars and picks or attempt to tunnel under them.

INTO BATTLE

Full-scale field battles were infrequent, but they were the ultimate test of a legionary's morale and fighting skills. Confronted with a "barbarian" army, the Romans had no crucial technological advantage on the battlefield. They did deploy field artillery in the form of small ballistae known as "scorpions", but although these were accurate and effective missile weapons they were not decisive. The Romans rarely made use of field fortifications, and then only to defend their flanks. It was the discipline, stamina, and strength of the legionary that so often brought victory. He was, it is true, better armoured than his opponents, but sword, spear, and shield were common to both sides. The savagery of close-quarters combat demanded emotional commitment to counter his inevitable fear. Here his bonding with comrades fighting alongside and identification with the honour of the cohort and legion would have their full effect.

But the Roman legionaries were not invincible. In 53 BCE they were worsted by Parthian archers at Carrhae. In 9 CE three Roman legions were surrounded and massacred in the Teutoburg Forest by German tribes led by Arminius. The Ninth Legion was partially destroyed by Queen Boudicca of the Iceni in 60 CE, before the 14th and 20th Legions defeated her and reasserted Roman power in Britain. But their record of success against enemies from outside and within the Empire in the first two centuries of the Christian era was impressive.

From the 3rd century CE the legions often became tools in the power struggles of ambitious leaders. Economic problems led to the adoption of cheaper armour and political disruption made armies much harder to raise and supply. Most of the soldiers of the late Empire were conscripts and the distinction between the citizen-legionaries and "barbarian" auxiliaries was largely lost. But the eventual fall of the Roman Empire in the west in the 5th century CE was not the result of defeats suffered by the legions, and much of the tradition of the Roman army was preserved by the Empire in the east.



Roman artillery
A team of legionaries mans a ballista. Two of them prepare to winch back the bowstring into the firing position. This kind of ballista could fire stone projectiles or heavy darts.